

PART A

Answer all questions in one or two sentences.

(1 mark each — $10 \times 1 = 10$ marks)

1. What does Virginia Woolf mean by “a room of one’s own”?
 2. Who is Aunt Jennifer in Adrienne Rich’s poem?
 3. What is the symbolic meaning of the “tigers” in *Aunt Jennifer’s Tigers*?
 4. Name the author of *The Slayer Slain*.
 5. What theme is highlighted in Alice Walker’s essay *In Search of Our Mothers’ Gardens*?
 6. Who wrote the poem *Lady Lazarus*?
 7. What is the central issue discussed in *I am not That Woman*?
 8. Mention the setting of Katherine Mansfield’s *The Fly*.
 9. Who are Molly and James in Sheila Walsh’s play?
 10. What does the title *The Grass Blade* symbolize?
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PART B

Answer any eight questions in a paragraph not exceeding 100 words.

(2 marks each — $8 \times 2 = 16$ marks)

11. Explain the significance of Shakespeare’s sister in Woolf’s essay.
 12. How does Alice Walker celebrate black women’s creativity?
 13. Comment on the tone of *Poetry* by Marianne Moore.
 14. Explain the imagery used in *A Musical Instrument*.
 15. What is the importance of spelling in Margaret Atwood’s poem *Spelling*?
 16. Describe the character of Lady Lazarus.
 17. Discuss the theme of oppression in *I am not That Woman*.
 18. Write a short note on the narrative technique in *Rules of the Game*.
 19. How does *A Wall is Safer* portray women’s insecurity?
 20. Comment on the symbolism in *The Fly*.
 21. What social issues are raised in *The Swing of Desire*?
 22. Describe the feminist concerns in *Inside Every Woman Writer*.
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PART C

Answer any six questions in about 200 words.

(4 marks each — $6 \times 4 = 24$ marks)

23. Discuss Woolf’s views on women and creativity.
 24. Analyse the concept of Indian feminism in Jasbir Jain’s essay.
 25. Examine the poetic techniques in *Lady Lazarus*.
 26. Discuss the significance of memory and identity in *Woman* by Nikki Giovanni.
 27. Analyse the feminist voice in Margaret Atwood’s *Spelling*.
 28. Discuss the theme of silence and expression in *The Grass Blade*.
 29. Examine the relationship between gender and power in *The Slayer Slain*.
 30. Analyse the characterisation in *Rules of the Game*.
 31. Discuss how Mansfield presents grief and trauma in *The Fly*.
 32. Comment on the dramatic elements in *Molly and James*.
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PART D

Answer any two questions in about 400 words.

(15 marks each — $2 \times 15 = 30$ marks)

33. “Women’s literature gives voice to the silenced experiences of women.” Discuss with reference to the prescribed texts.
34. Analyse *The Slayer Slain* as a feminist novel.
35. Critically examine the representation of patriarchy in the poems prescribed for study.
36. Discuss the major themes and feminist concerns in the short stories prescribed in the syllabus.

prepare answer key for this same PART A Answer all questions in one or two sentences. (1 mark each — $10 \times 1 = 10$ marks)
What does Virginia Woolf mean by “a room of one’s own”? Who is Aunt Jennifer in Adrienne Rich’s poem? What is the symbolic meaning of the “tigers” in Aunt Jennifer’s Tigers? Name the author of *The Slayer Slain*. What theme is highlighted in Alice Walker’s essay *In Search of Our Mothers’ Gardens*? Who wrote the poem *Lady Lazarus*? What is the central issue discussed in *I am not That Woman*? Mention the setting of Katherine Mansfield’s *The Fly*. Who are Molly and James in Sheila Walsh’s play? What does the title *The Grass Blade* symbolize? PART B Answer any eight questions in a paragraph not exceeding 100 words. (2 marks each — $8 \times 2 = 16$ marks) Explain the significance of Shakespeare’s sister in Woolf’s essay. How does Alice Walker celebrate black women’s creativity? Comment on the tone of *Poetry* by Marianne Moore. Explain the imagery used in *A Musical Instrument*. What is the importance of spelling in Margaret Atwood’s poem *Spelling*? Describe the character of *Lady Lazarus*. Discuss the theme of oppression in *I am not That Woman*. Write a short note on the narrative technique in *Rules of the Game*. How does *A Wall is Safer* portray women’s insecurity? Comment on the symbolism in *The Fly*. What social issues are raised in *The Swing of Desire*? Describe the feminist concerns in *Inside Every Woman Writer*. PART C Answer any six questions in about 200 words. (4 marks each — $6 \times 4 = 24$ marks) Discuss Woolf’s views on women and creativity. Analyse the concept of Indian feminism in Jasbir Jain’s essay. Examine the poetic techniques in *Lady Lazarus*. Discuss the significance of memory and identity in *Woman* by Nikki Giovanni. Analyse the feminist voice in Margaret Atwood’s *Spelling*. Discuss the theme of silence and expression in *The Grass Blade*. Examine the relationship between gender and power in *The Slayer Slain*. Analyse the characterisation in *Rules of the Game*. Discuss how Mansfield presents grief and trauma in *The Fly*. Comment on the dramatic elements in *Molly and James*. PART D Answer any two questions in about 400 words. (15 marks each — $2 \times 15 = 30$ marks) “Women’s literature gives voice to the silenced experiences of women.” Discuss with reference to the prescribed texts. Analyse *The Slayer Slain* as a feminist novel. Critically examine the representation of patriarchy in the poems prescribed for study. Discuss the major themes and feminist concerns in the short stories prescribed in the syllabus.

ANSWER KEY

MGU CBCSS (2011–2014 Scheme)

B.A. Communicative English with Literature

Women’s Literature

PART A – ANSWERS

(1 Mark Each)

1. Virginia Woolf means that women need financial independence and personal space to create literature and express themselves freely.
 2. Aunt Jennifer is a woman trapped in an oppressive marriage in Adrienne Rich’s poem.
 3. The tigers symbolize freedom, courage, strength, and the fearless spirit denied to Aunt Jennifer.
 4. *The Slayer Slain* was written by Frances Collins.
 5. Alice Walker’s essay highlights the suppressed creativity and artistic heritage of black women.
 6. *Lady Lazarus* was written by Sylvia Plath.
 7. *I am not That Woman* discusses the oppression and objectification of women in patriarchal society.
 8. *The Fly* is set mainly in the office of the boss after World War I.
 9. Molly and James are the central characters in Sheila Walsh’s play dealing with marital and emotional conflicts.
 10. The title *The Grass Blade* symbolizes resilience, survival, and silent resistance.
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PART B – ANSWERS

(2 Marks Each)

11. Shakespeare's sister symbolizes the denied opportunities of talented women in a patriarchal society. Woolf imagines that even if Shakespeare had an equally gifted sister, social restrictions would have prevented her from becoming a writer.
 12. Alice Walker celebrates black women's creativity by showing how they expressed their artistic talents through gardening, quilting, music, and storytelling despite oppression and lack of recognition.
 13. The tone of Marianne Moore's *Poetry* is ironic, critical, and reflective. She questions traditional ideas of poetry while appreciating genuine imagination and sincerity in literature.
 14. In *A Musical Instrument*, Browning uses vivid natural imagery such as reeds, rivers, and forests. These images show how artistic creation often involves pain and destruction.
 15. In *Spelling*, spelling symbolizes women's search for identity, language, freedom, and self-expression. It represents the power to define oneself.
 16. Lady Lazarus is portrayed as bold, rebellious, and dramatic. She repeatedly survives death-like experiences and challenges male authority and societal control.
 17. The poem presents women as victims of social oppression and objectification. The speaker rejects the stereotypical image forced upon women by patriarchal culture.
 18. *Rules of the Game* uses first-person narration through the voice of Waverly Jong. The story combines personal experience, cultural conflict, and symbolism related to chess.
 19. *A Wall is Safer* portrays the fear and insecurity experienced by women in society. The wall symbolizes emotional protection and isolation from violence and oppression.
 20. In *The Fly*, the fly symbolizes human suffering, helplessness, and the emotional trauma caused by war and personal loss.
 21. *The Swing of Desire* raises issues such as gender inequality, social restrictions, emotional repression, and women's desire for freedom and individuality.
 22. *Inside Every Woman Writer* explores the struggles faced by women writers in a male-dominated literary world and highlights issues of identity, creativity, and social expectations.
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PART C – ANSWERS

(4 Marks Each)

23. Virginia Woolf argues that women have historically been denied education, freedom, and financial independence, which prevented them from developing their creative talents. She insists that a woman needs "money and a room of her own" to write fiction. Woolf criticizes patriarchal society for silencing women's voices and excluding them from literary traditions. Through the example of Shakespeare's imaginary sister, she demonstrates how talented women were discouraged and suppressed. Woolf advocates intellectual freedom and equal opportunities for women writers.
24. Jasbir Jain explains that Indian feminism differs from Western feminism because it is shaped by Indian culture, caste, class, religion, and tradition. She argues that Indian feminism questions patriarchal structures while balancing social and family responsibilities. Jain emphasizes the need for women to search for identity and space within society and literature. She highlights the diversity of women's experiences in India and encourages resistance against gender discrimination.
25. *Lady Lazarus* uses confessional style, dramatic monologue, irony, symbolism, repetition, and vivid imagery. Sylvia Plath compares the speaker's repeated survival to resurrection. Holocaust imagery and references to death intensify the emotional impact. The poem's conversational tone and powerful metaphors express anger, rebellion, and resistance against male domination. The poem also reflects themes of identity and self-destruction.
26. In Nikki Giovanni's *Woman*, memory and identity are closely connected to women's struggles and sacrifices. The poem portrays a woman attempting to create a meaningful life while facing disappointment and hardship. Her identity is shaped by dreams, responsibilities, and emotional pain. Giovanni presents womanhood as both creative and difficult, emphasizing resilience and self-awareness.
27. Margaret Atwood's *Spelling* presents a strong feminist voice by connecting language with women's empowerment. The poem suggests that naming and spelling are acts of control and identity formation. Women have historically been denied the power of language and expression. Through the metaphor of spelling, Atwood emphasizes the struggle for self-definition and freedom. The poem highlights women's silent resistance against patriarchal limitations.
28. *The Grass Blade* explores silence and expression through the image of a small blade of grass that survives despite oppression. The poem suggests that even weak voices can express resistance and hope. Silence becomes both a sign of suffering and a form of hidden strength. The grass blade symbolizes endurance and quiet rebellion against authority.
29. *The Slayer Slain* examines how patriarchal power controls women's lives and identities. Gender roles restrict freedom and create unequal relationships between men and women. Female characters struggle against oppression and attempt to assert independence. The novel exposes how power operates through social expectations and traditional structures. It presents resistance as necessary for self-realization.
30. In *Rules of the Game*, Amy Tan carefully develops Waverly Jong as an intelligent and ambitious girl. Her mother is portrayed as strict, proud, and controlling. The relationship between mother and daughter reflects cultural conflict and generational tension. Chess becomes a symbol of strategy, power, and personal identity. The characters are realistic and psychologically complex.

31. Katherine Mansfield presents grief and trauma through the character of the boss, who struggles to cope with the death of his son in the war. The fly episode reflects his emotional state and helplessness. The repeated suffering of the fly symbolizes human pain and the cruelty of fate. Mansfield uses symbolism and psychological narration to explore suppressed sorrow and emotional emptiness.
 32. *Molly and James* contains dramatic conflict, emotional dialogue, realistic characterization, and tension between personal desires and social expectations. The play explores marital relationships and gender roles. Dialogue reveals the inner emotions of the characters, while dramatic situations expose misunderstandings and emotional struggles. The realistic style strengthens the social message of the play.
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PART D – ANSWERS

(15 Marks Each)

33. Women's literature gives voice to the silenced experiences of women by exposing oppression, inequality, and emotional struggles. In Virginia Woolf's essay, women are shown as historically denied education and creative freedom. Alice Walker celebrates the hidden creativity of black women whose talents remained unrecognized. Poems like *Aunt Jennifer's Tigers* and *I am not That Woman* portray women trapped within patriarchal systems but longing for freedom and self-expression.

In *Lady Lazarus*, Sylvia Plath expresses rebellion against male authority and social control. Margaret Atwood's *Spelling* connects language with identity and empowerment. The short stories also explore women's experiences of insecurity, cultural conflict, and emotional isolation. *A Wall is Safer* highlights fear and vulnerability, while *Inside Every Woman Writer* examines the difficulties faced by female writers.

The plays and novel further present women resisting social expectations and struggling for independence. Together, these texts challenge patriarchal norms and recover women's voices, identities, and experiences that were previously ignored or silenced.

34. *The Slayer Slain* can be read as a feminist novel because it questions patriarchal authority and gender inequality. The novel portrays women as individuals struggling against social restrictions and male domination. Female characters face emotional and social oppression but attempt to assert their independence and identity.

The novel examines how power structures control women's choices and limit their freedom. Traditional expectations force women into subordinate roles, creating conflict and suffering. Through characterization and narrative development, the novel exposes injustice and gender discrimination.

The title itself suggests resistance and reversal of power. Women are no longer passive victims but active challengers of oppression. The novel promotes self-awareness, resistance, and empowerment. It highlights the need for women to reclaim their voices and identities within society.

35. Patriarchy is strongly represented in the prescribed poems through images of oppression, silence, and resistance. In *Aunt Jennifer's Tigers*, Aunt Jennifer's fear of her husband reflects the burden of male dominance. The tigers symbolize the freedom she cannot achieve in real life.

In *Lady Lazarus*, Sylvia Plath challenges patriarchal authority through anger and rebellion. *I am not That Woman* criticizes the objectification and commodification of women in society. Margaret Atwood's *Spelling* shows how women struggle to gain control over language and identity.

Nikki Giovanni's *Woman* portrays the emotional sacrifices women make while trying to build meaningful lives. Even poems like *The Grass Blade* suggest quiet resistance against oppressive structures. Through symbolism, imagery, and strong feminist voices, these poems expose the damaging effects of patriarchy while encouraging resistance and empowerment.

36. The prescribed short stories deal with themes such as grief, identity, cultural conflict, women's insecurity, and feminist resistance. Katherine Mansfield's *The Fly* explores grief and emotional trauma after war. The fly symbolizes human suffering and helplessness.

Shashi Deshpande's *A Wall is Safer* portrays women's fear and insecurity in a patriarchal society. The story highlights emotional isolation and the need for protection. Sara Joseph's *Inside Every Woman Writer* examines the struggles faced by women writers who seek creative freedom in a male-dominated society.

Amy Tan's *Rules of the Game* focuses on mother-daughter relationships, cultural identity, and personal ambition. Chess symbolizes strategy and control within family relationships. Together, these stories reveal women's emotional experiences and challenge traditional social structures through feminist perspectives.